The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Donald Trump said that American negotiators would return to Islamabad, the capital of Pakistan, on Monday for further talks with **Iranian** officials. Talks last weekend ended without agreement. Writing on Truth Social, Mr Trump mocked Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz on Saturday, a day after its reopening: it was "strange, because our BLOCKADE has already closed it". He threatened to destroy Iran's power stations and bridges if no deal was reached.

Iran had blamed America's blockade for its re-closing of the strait. The country's armed forces accused America of "failing to meet commitments" and said that any vessel approaching the strait would now be "targeted". The announcement came shortly before reports that two ships had come under fire from Iranian gunboats.

North Korea fired several ballistic missiles into its eastern waters. The country has now carried out four such launches this month. South Korea urged its neighbour to "stop the provocative acts". Earlier this week, the International Atomic Energy Agency, the global nuclear watchdog, said North Korea had made "very serious" progress towards building nuclear weapons.

Brazil, **Mexico** and **Spain** issued a joint statement expressing "deep concern" over the "serious humanitarian crisis" in **Cuba**. The island is suffering from fuel shortages and blackouts caused partly by an oil blockade imposed by America. The statement did not mention America by name but called for "sincere and respectful" dialogue. The three countries also pledged to send more aid.

Australia's most decorated soldier has denied allegations of committing war crimes. Ben Roberts-Smith was released on bail on Friday after five counts—including killing unarmed Afghan detainees—were brought against him last week. In his first statement since, the former corporal of Australia's Special Air Service pledged to fight the charges and "clear [his] name".

At least six people were killed and several injured after a man opened fire on a street in **Kyiv**, Ukraine's capital, and then took hostages in a supermarket on Saturday. The gunman, identified by Ukraine's attorney-general as a 58-year-old born in Moscow, was killed after police stormed the shop. His motive remains unclear. Such incidents are rare in Ukraine.

Blue Origin launched a rocket with a reused booster for the first time. The heavy-lift **New Glenn** rocket, which has so far completed three flights, took off from Cape Canaveral in Florida carrying an internet satellite for orbit. The successful return of the reused hardware should help Jeff Bezos's space company to compete with Elon Musk's SpaceX and its Falcon 9 rocket.

Word of the week: "Passport bros", Western men who go abroad to find traditional wives. Read about how frustration with modern dating has fuelled the social-media movement.

Photograph: EPA

South Korea flirts with new partners

Lee Jae Myung, South Korea's president, begins a three-day state visit to India on Sunday. The trip is the first by a South Korean leader in eight years and marks the start of a charm offensive on developing countries. Mr Lee will travel with a delegation of 200 business leaders, including bosses from Samsung, Hyundai and LG. Mr Lee and Narendra Modi, India's prime minister, will hold a summit on AI, defence and shipbuilding.

Mr Lee's courtship of India represents a pivot away from South Korea's deep but strained alliances with America, China and Japan. With the war in Iran disrupting the flow of crude oil, on which South Korea heavily relies, the country is keen to secure new energy supplies and manufacturing hubs. The two countries aim to reach $50bn in bilateral trade by 2030. Known for appearing in slick videos, Mr Lee may draw millions to his TikTok profile, but it is his pragmatism that will be on show this weekend.

Photograph: Getty Images

Bulgaria goes to the polls, again

Bulgarians vote on Sunday in their eighth parliamentary election in five years. Most polls put a former president, Rumen Radev, and his newly formed Progressive Bulgaria party in the lead. Also in the running is Boyko Borissov, a three-time prime minister and former bodyguard, whose ideologically colourless GERB ("coat of arms") party was ousted after anti-government protests in December.

Mr Radev, a former fighter pilot, has pledged to clean up Bulgaria's "mafia state" and to root out oligarchs, who he accuses Mr Borissov's party of being in cahoots with. As president Mr Radev spoke out against the EU's support for Ukraine and the West's sanctions against Russia. And some fear that he could become a new spoiler in Brussels, like Hungary's Viktor Orban, who lost power last week. Still, polls suggest that Mr Radev's party could win 31% of the vote, which would leave him short of a parliamentary majority. The search for coalition partners may force him to compromise.

Photograph: Getty Images

Humanoids race towards the future

More than 100 humanoid robots competed against humans in a half-marathon in Beijing on Sunday. The winner, made by Honor, a Chinese phonemaker, completed the course in 50 minutes and 26 seconds—several minutes faster than the human world record, set by Jacob Kiplimo last month in Lisbon. (Unlike the robot, Mr Kiplimo didn't crash into a railing metres before the finish line.)

The event, which is intended to spur innovation and competition in a sector prized by the Chinese state, expanded notably from last year's inaugural race, in which just 21 robots competed and which only six finished. Almost all were remotely steered by humans. Technical problems, such as tripping over and overheating, slowed down the race. The stakes were lower, too: the winner took home just 5,000 yuan ($730) in prize money. This year roughly 40% of the starters were autonomous. As well as the race, they were competing for guaranteed orders totalling more than 1m yuan.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Asim Munir, Donald Trump’s favourite field-marshal

Descending from his plane onto the Tehran tarmac on April 15th, Asim Munir looked every inch the military strongman. The mustachioed chief of Pakistan’s army wore fatigues and a black beret and carried a baton, a symbol of his rank as field-marshal. He greeted Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, with a salute, followed by a bear hug.

Officially, Field-Marshal Munir has no role in foreign policy. Yet he brokered the temporary ceasefire between Iran and America. On April 11th in Pakistan’s capital he hosted the first meeting between delegations from the two countries in almost 50 years. Now he is engineering a second, perhaps this time including Donald Trump, who has called him his “favourite field-marshal”. Although Pakistan has a civilian government, Field-Marshal Munir is the country’s most powerful person.

Such a career would have seemed improbable back in 2019, when Pakistan’s then prime minister, Imran Khan, removed him from the powerful post of spy chief. But after Mr Khan, a cricketer-turned-populist-superstar, was ousted by the political and military establishment, then-General Munir was brought back into the fold. He was appointed army chief in 2022, and quickly secured his grip on the armed forces by locking up rivals.

His making, however, was a four-day war with India last year. The downing of five Indian jets inspired a wave of Pakistani patriotism. General Munir took advantage, getting himself promoted to the armed forces' highest rank (he is the second person ever to reach it), and ramming through constitutional changes to expand his role and extend his tenure. He is now the most powerful Pakistani leader since Pervez Musharraf, a military officer-turned-dictator who was deposed in 2008.

Field-Marshal Munir is the son of an imam, and the first army chief who can recite the Koran by heart. He is secretive, an unsurprising quality in a former leader of the foreign- and military-intelligence agencies. One of the few journalists to have met him reveals only that he has a firm handshake and smokes Dunhill Blue cigarettes. Less mysterious is his vision for Pakistan, which involves military strength, confronting India and the Afghan Taliban and closer ties with other Muslim powers, from Turkey to Saudi Arabia.

He is sharp, wily, ambitious and ruthless, say those who have watched his rise. But if that has helped to bring success abroad, it has been coupled with deepening repression at home. Mr Khan is in solitary confinement; hundreds more politicians have been jailed and media freedom has been curtailed. "Our generation thought we'd left this behind us," says Mustafa Khokhar, vice-chairman of the opposition alliance. If he achieves more diplomatic success Field-Marshal Munir will become even more powerful at home.

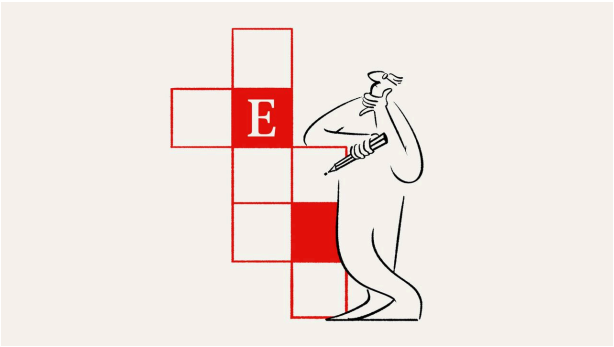

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Stormont sides with global conflict (6)

2 across - Explosive noble prize-giver (5)

3 across - Kevin or Malcolm have ordinary feature (6)

1 down - What learners owe after graduation stunned a lot (7,4)

Straight clues

1 across - Discord, argument (6)

2 across - Inventor of dynamite and founder of coveted prizes (5)

3 across - Usual, conventional (6)

4 across - Money borrowed to pay for university (7,4)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of the week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Jeff Schock, Olympia, Washington, America
John Biggs, Sheffield, Britain
Luis Llanos, Santiago, Chile

They all gave the correct answers of: Ken Burns, Flanders, Maggie Gyllenhaal, the Mona Lisa and Homer. The theme is characters from "The Simpsons": Mr Burns, Ned Flanders, Maggie, Lisa and Homer Simpson.

The questions were:

Monday: Which American film-maker is known for documentary series on the US civil war, baseball and the Vietnam war?

Tuesday: Brussels is the capital of which region in Belgium?

Wednesday: Which American actress and film-maker directed the 2026 movie "The Bride!"?

Thursday: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

Friday: Which Greek poet is generally credited as the writer of the Iliad and the Odyssey?

The greatest deception men suffer is from their own opinions

Leonardo da Vinci